

Education Indicator

EDUCATION AND LEARNING OUTCOMES

Retention of students in senior secondary schools

In 2024, 81% of school leavers remained at school until their 17th birthday, up 1.7 percentage points from 2023. This was a decrease of 3.4 percentage points in the retention rate since 2014. Retention of senior students has dropped by 4.0 percentage points since the peak in 2015.

Indicator Description

Percentage of school leavers remaining at school until at least age 17.

Why is staying in school important?

Completion of senior secondary education is associated with a range of economic and social benefits both in New Zealand and across the OECD. Retention to senior secondary schooling is linked to higher levels of skills and knowledge required for participation in our increasingly knowledge-based society and the wider global community, as workers are required to adapt to the uncertainties and change they are confronted with (OECD, 2022).

According to Norton (2000), the risk of unemployment for those with no school qualifications or only Year 11 qualifications is higher than for those with Year 12 or Year 13 qualifications. The positive effect of each additional year of schooling on incomes has been estimated to range from 5 to 10%.

Lashlie (2005), found that one of the factors important for successful school leaving for boys is merely staying at school until the end of Year 13. This is because it takes boys longer to achieve a similar level of maturity and self-management to girls, and boys' schools, in particular, can "hold boys steady while the chaos of adolescence sorts itself". Simply keeping boys at school (by making school relevant) until they have decided what they want their next step in life to be can reduce the chances of a boy "arriving at a prison gate".

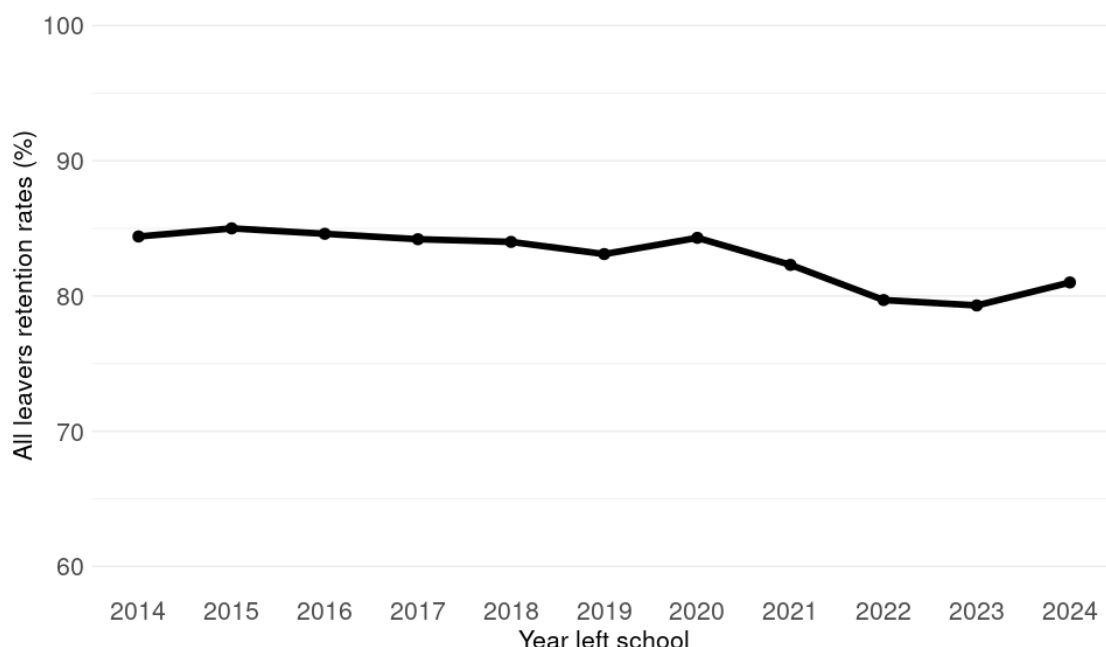
How are we going

In 2024, 81.0% of school leavers stayed at school to the age of 17 or above, a 1.7 percentage point increase from 2023 (79.3%). Retention peaked in 2015 at 85.0% and has decreased by 4.0% since 2015 as shown in Figure 1.

There has been a consistent pattern of female school leavers staying in school longer than males. In 2024, female school leavers (83.5%) were more likely to remain at school until at least age 17 than their male counterparts (78.5%).

The proportion of school leavers staying in school until at least age 17 in 2024 has increased for all ethnic groupings. Asian school leavers (93.0%) had the highest rates of retention to at least age 17 in 2024, followed by European/Pākehā (81.4%), Pacific (79.8%), and Māori (67.1%).

Figure 1: The proportion of school leavers who remained at school until their 17th birthday or above increased in 2024



Among young leavers aged less than 17, often the reason given for leaving school was simply “end of schooling” (60.9% of 2024 school leavers aged less than 17). Other reasons which were common for school leavers under the age of 17 were continuous absence¹, having gone overseas, and being granted an early leaving exemption.

- The proportion of school leavers who left school before age 17 due to being continuously absent was 15.9% in 2024, an increase of 1.1 percentage point from 2023. This was the highest rate since 2014.
- The proportion of school leavers who left school before age 17 due to moving overseas increased in 2024 to 8.8% which was higher than in 2023 (6.4%) and 2022 (5.2%).

¹ Continuous absence is when a student does not attend school for 20 consecutive school days without informing the principal that the absence is only temporary, after which the principal is required to record the student as having left the school.



It is compulsory for students to be enrolled and attending school up until 16 years of age. However, each year there is small proportion of students who leave school before reaching age 16 and therefore they don't complete compulsory education. In 2024, there were 2,881 students who left school before age 16, of which 1,244 were due to continuous absence from school.

There were 1,254 school leavers who had an early leaving exemption (0.8% of all school leavers, a decrease from 2,371, or 1.7% of school leavers in 2023). However, there were a number of school leavers aged 15 or less on their last day at school who left school without an early leaving exemption. There were a total of 6,567 school leavers aged less than 16 on their last day in 2024 (4.4%), a decrease from 6,766 school leavers in 2023 (4.8%).

Enrolment patterns

Retention to 17-years of age is influenced by the size of the Year 10-13 cohorts in school and the retention within each year level. Compared to 2023, in 2024, there were more learners in Years 10-13 and improvements in retention were influenced by a higher proportion of the learners being retained in school to Years 11-13 in 2025².

Year 10 to Year 13 enrolments have increased from 2020- 2024.

- Year 10 enrolments increased from 62,251 students in 2020 to 71,978 students in 2024, a 15.6% increase. Similarly, the number of students who returned to school the next year increased from 57,137 students in 2020 to 65,172 students in 2024, an increase of 14.1%.
- Year 11 enrolments increased from 61,046 students in 2020 to 70,141 students in 2024, a 14.9% increase. Similarly, the number of students who returned to school the next year increased from 54,150 students in 2020 to 61,394 students in 2024, an increase of 13.4%.
- Year 12 enrolments increased by 12.7% from 2020- 2024, while retention increased by 12.9% in the same period, showing a gap of 0.2 percentage points between enrolment and retention.
- Year 13 enrolments increased by 7.8% from 2020- 2024, while the number of students who returned to school increased by 74.9% in the same period. This shows that while more students enrolled in Year 13, more of these school leavers returned to school in the next year after Year 13.

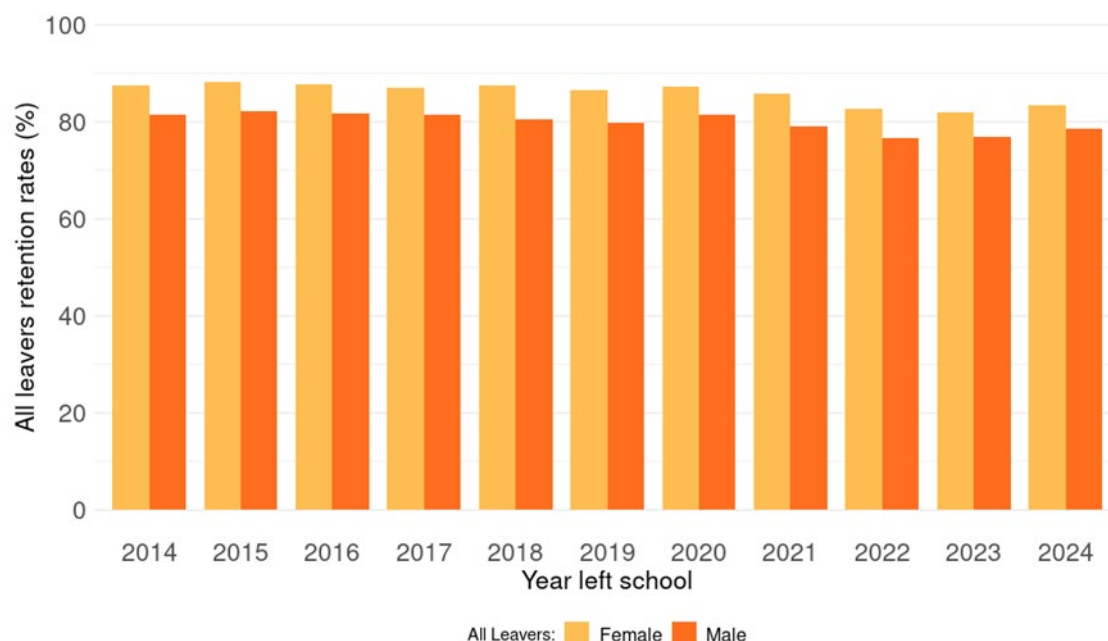
Gender

Since 2014, retention to at least age 17 has been higher for female school leavers. In 2024, 83.5% of female school leavers stayed in school until at least age 17, compared to 78.5% of male school leavers (Figure 2).

Compared to 2023, female school leavers experienced a 1.6 percentage point increase in the retention rate, while the retention rate for male leavers increased by 1.7%. This has narrowed the gender gap from 5.2 percentage points in 2023 to 5.1 percentage points in 2024.

² Number of Year 10, 11, 12 and 13 students are from the roll-based measure of NZ Domestic students in Years 10-13 in 2023.



Figure 2: Retention to at least age 17 was higher for female school leavers

Socioeconomic barriers³

At a system level, schools where students experience more socioeconomic barriers to achievement have lower retention rates. This indicates there is an association between retention rates and socioeconomic background.

In 2024, schools where students had the fewest barriers to achievement had a retention rate of 94% and those where students had the most barriers to achievement had a retention rate of 64.5 percentage points.

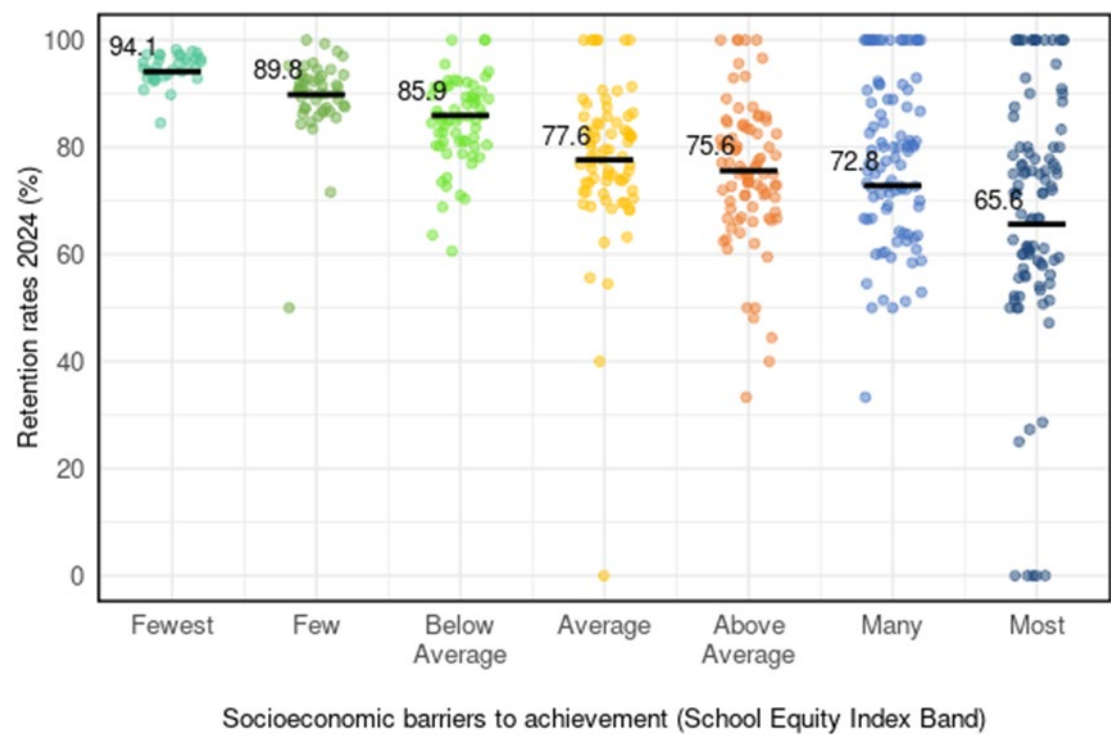
Figure 3 shows the distribution of retention rates for school leavers in 2024, by School Equity Index Band. There was variation in the percentage of school leavers remaining at school until at least age 17 among schools within each School Equity Index Band.

Schools where students had the fewest barriers to achievement had similar retention rates, as shown by the closer proximity of dots closer to the average retention rate of 94.1%. As barriers to achievement increased, the differences in retention rates across schools also increased. The biggest variations in retention rates were in schools where students had the most barriers to achievement. Within this group, there were 94 schools, of which 54 schools had retention rates at or above the average rate of 64.5% in 2024. About 40 schools had retention rates ranging from 0% to 94%.

³ For more information about the School Equity Index see the section at the end of this indicator report.



Figure 3: Variation in the percentage of 2024 school leavers staying in school to age 17 amongst schools within each School Equity Index Band



Ethnicity⁴

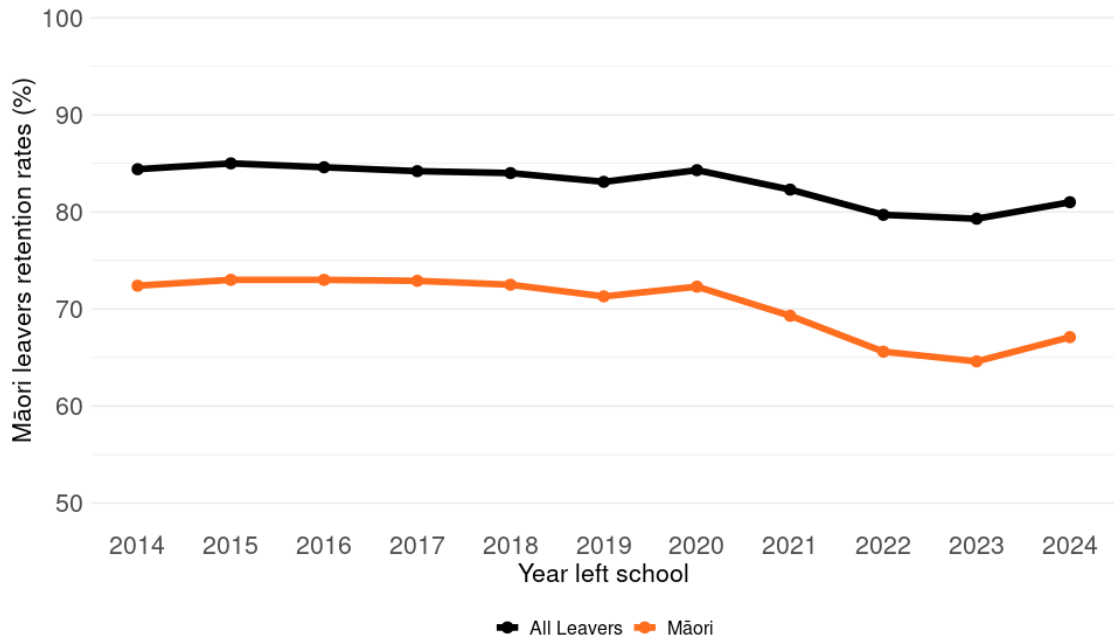
Compared to 2023, the proportion of school leavers staying in school until at least age 17 in 2024 increased for all ethnic groupings.

Māori school leavers

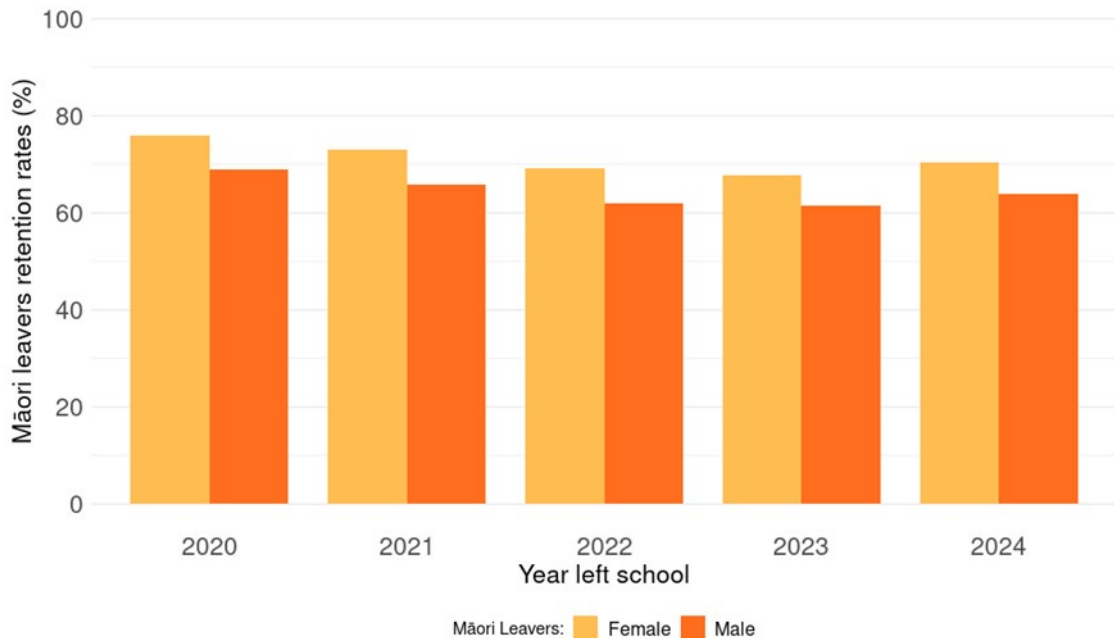
The education system does not support ākonga Māori to engage in school until age 17 or above as well as it does for students from other ethnic groups. In 2024, 67.1% of Māori school leavers remained at school until at least age 17, a 2.5 percentage point increase from 2023. Between 2016 (peak retention for Māori leavers) and 2024, the retention rate decreased by 5.9 percentage points. Between 2020 and 2024, the retention rate decreased by 5.2 percentage points. The gap in retention rates between Māori school leavers who remained in school until age 17 and all school leavers was 13.8% in 2024, down from 14.7% in 2023 as shown in Figure 4.

⁴ Total response ethnicity counts school leavers who identify with more than one ethnic group in each of these ethnic groups. For the New Zealand total, individuals are counted only once.



Figure 4: The gap in student retention between Māori and all leavers decreased slightly in 2024

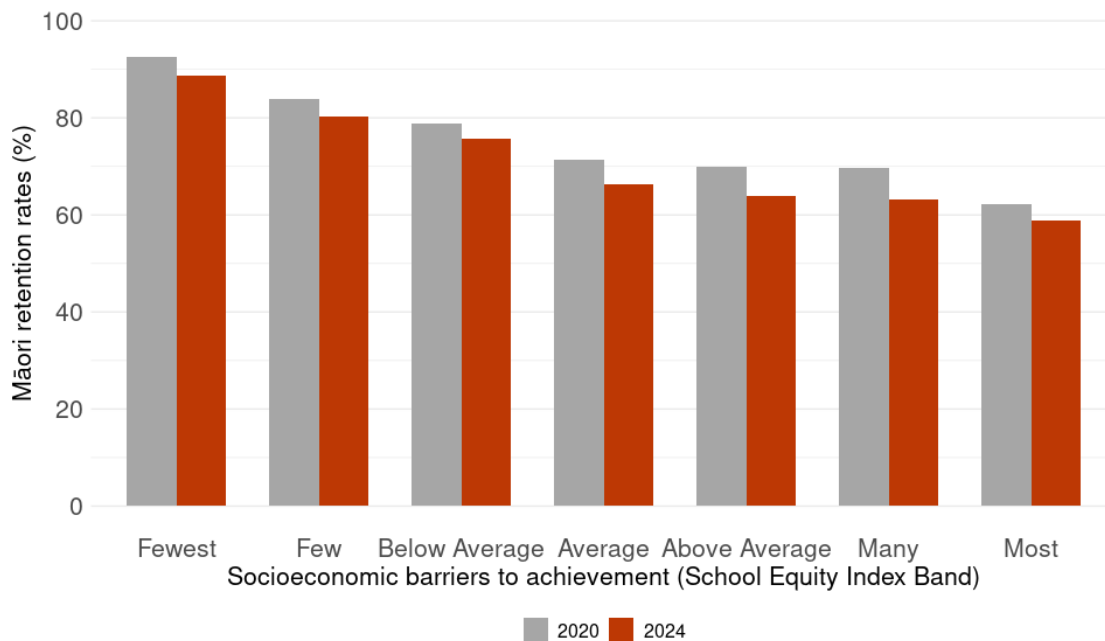
In 2024, 70.4 % of Māori female school leavers remained in school until at least age 17 compared to 63.9% of Māori male school leavers (Figure 5).

Figure 5: Proportion of Māori school leavers who remained in school until at least age 17, by gender

A higher proportion of Māori school leavers from schools where students had fewer barriers to achievement remained in school until at least age 17. In 2024, 88.8% of Māori school leavers from schools where students had the fewest barriers to achievement remained in school compared to 58.8% of Māori school leavers from schools where students had the most barriers to achievement (Figure 6).



Figure 6: Proportion of Māori school leavers who remained in school until at least age 17 in 2024, by Equity Index Bands



Most Māori school leavers who stay in school until at least age 17 leave school with NCEA Level 2 or above, which is considered to be the minimum level of preparation needed to pursue employment or further study. In 2024, 82.7% of Māori school leavers who stayed in school until at least age 17 left school with NCEA Level 2 or above, unchanged from 2023 and down 3.7 percentage points from 2020.

The gap between Māori school leavers who stayed in school until at least age 17 with NCEA Level 2 or above and all school leavers decreased to 6.3 percentage points in 2024 from a high of 7.7 percentage points in 2014. This gap was lowest in 2019 (5.1 percentage points) but has been increasing since then.

Māori and language of learning⁵

Māori predominantly learning in te reo Māori

Of the 16,861 Māori students in 2024, 5% (835 Māori school leavers) were predominantly learning in te reo Māori. The number of Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori has increased 74.7% since 2014 (478 Māori school leavers in 2014).

Note, that when looking at statistics based on small populations, such as the small number of school leavers learning in te reo Māori, a small change in numbers can result in a relatively large change in the proportions and therefore relatively large fluctuations from year to year.

In 2024, 77.6% of Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori remained at school until at least age 17, up 6.1 percentage points from 2023. (Figure 7)

⁵ The predominant language of learning is the one that school leavers are learning in at least 51% of the time.



The gap in retention rates between Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori and all school leavers decreased to 3.4 percentage points in 2024. In the last 10 years the difference has been as large as 10 percentage points (in 2022) and as low as 2.1 percentage points (in 2019).

In 2024, 92.6% of Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori and stayed in school until at least age 17 attained NCEA Level 2 or above. This was similar to 2023 (91.3%) and 2022 (91.1%).

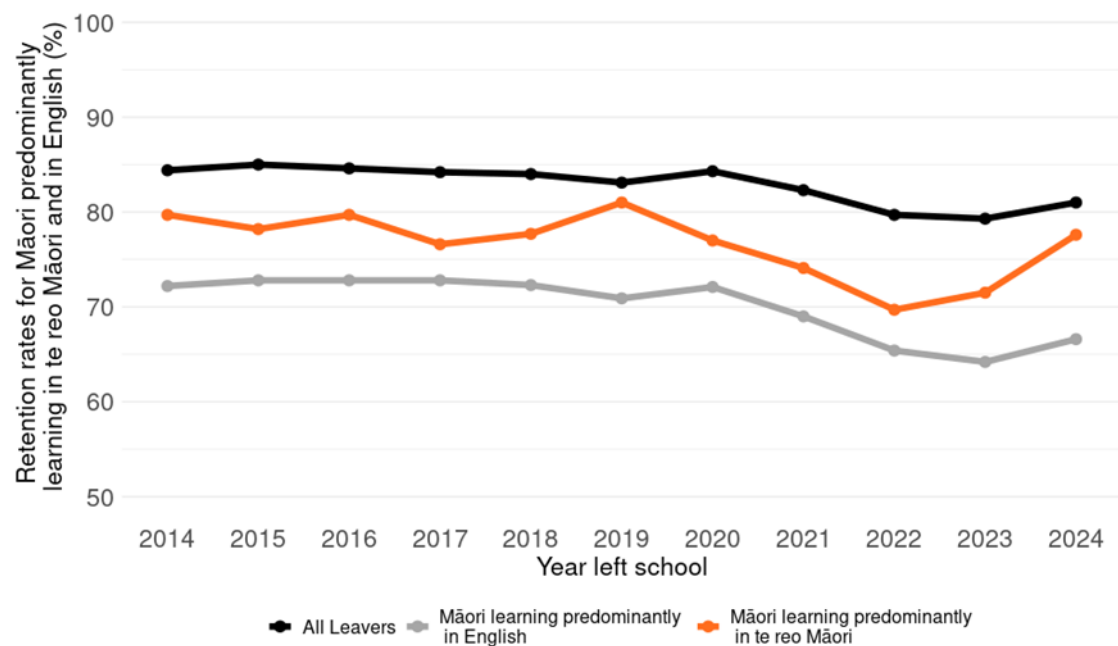
Māori predominantly learning in English

The retention rate for Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in English was 66.6%, up 2.4 percentage points from 2023 (Figure 7).

The gap in retention rates between Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in English and all school leavers decreased to 14.4 percentage points in 2024.

In 2024, 82.1% of Māori school leavers predominantly learning in English who stayed in school until at least age 17 attained NCEA Level 2 or above, down 0.1 percentage point from 2023 (82.2%) and 3.8 percentage points from 2020 (85.9%).

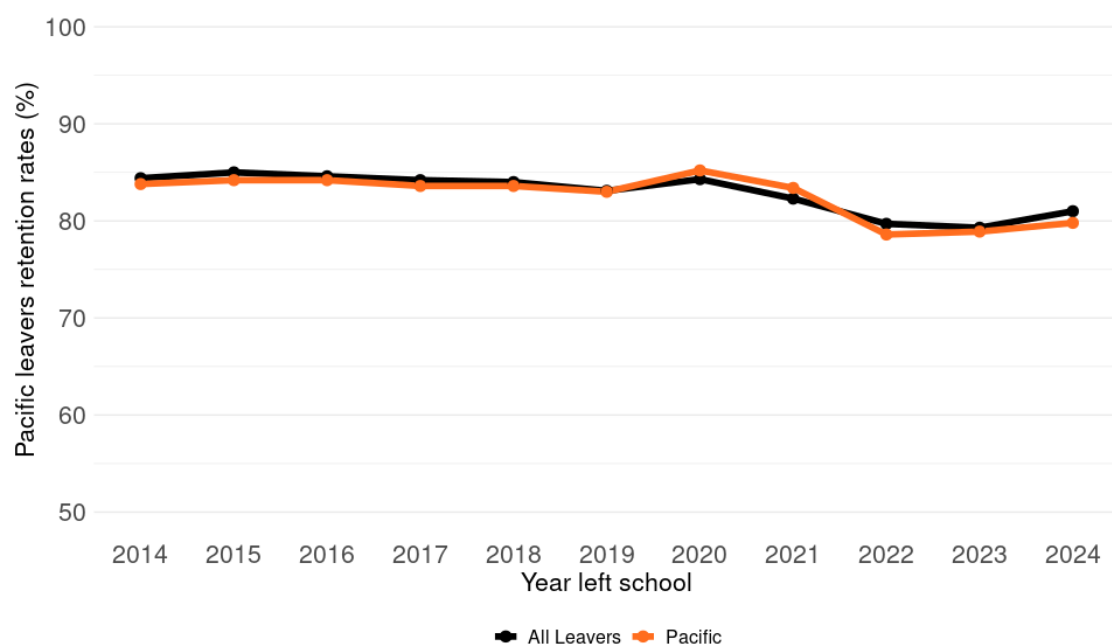
Figure 7: Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori had higher retention rates



Pacific school leavers

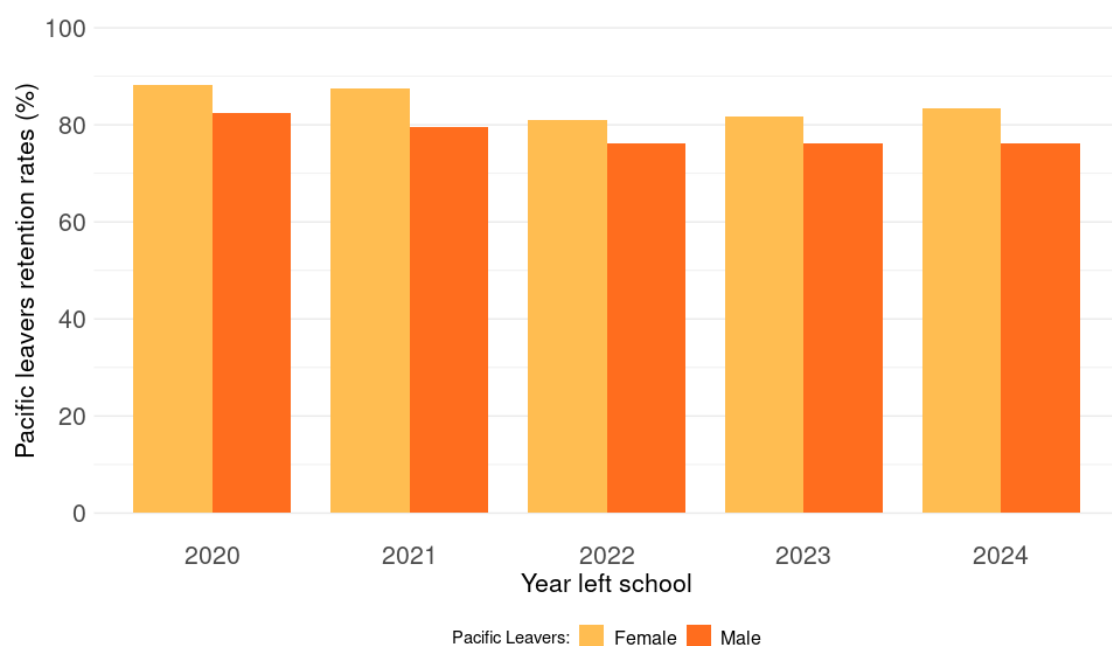
The retention rate for Pacific school leavers was similar to the rate for all leavers as shown in Figure 8. In 2024, 79.8% of Pacific school leavers remained at school until at least age 17, up 0.9 percentage points from 2023. Between 2020 (peak retention for Pacific leavers) and 2024, the rate decreased by 5.4 percentage points.

Figure 8: The retention rate for Pacific school leavers was similar to the national retention rate



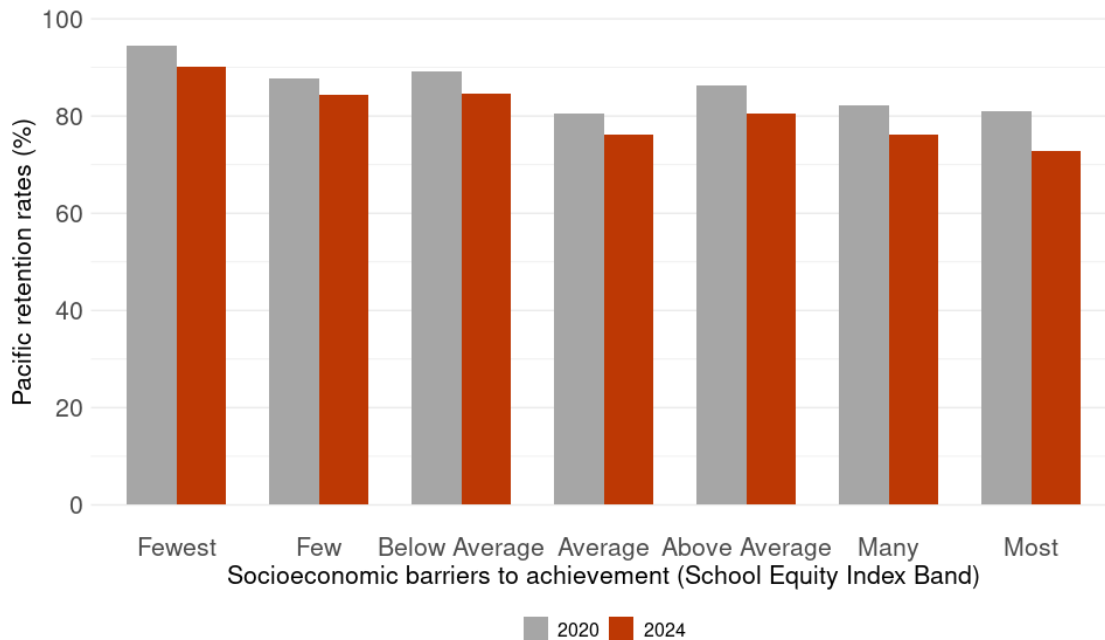
In 2024, 83.3% of Pacific female school leavers remained in school until at least age 17 compared to 76.3% of Pacific male school leavers (Figure 9).

Figure 9: Proportion of Pacific school leavers who remained in school until at least age 17, by gender



A higher proportion of Pacific school leavers from schools where students had fewer barriers to achievement remained in school until at least age 17. In 2024, 90.2% of Pacific leavers from schools where students had the fewest barriers to achievement remained in school compared to 72.7% of Pacific leavers from schools where students had the most barriers to achievement (Figure 10).

Figure 10: Proportion of Pacific school leavers who remained in school until at least age 17, by Equity Index Bands



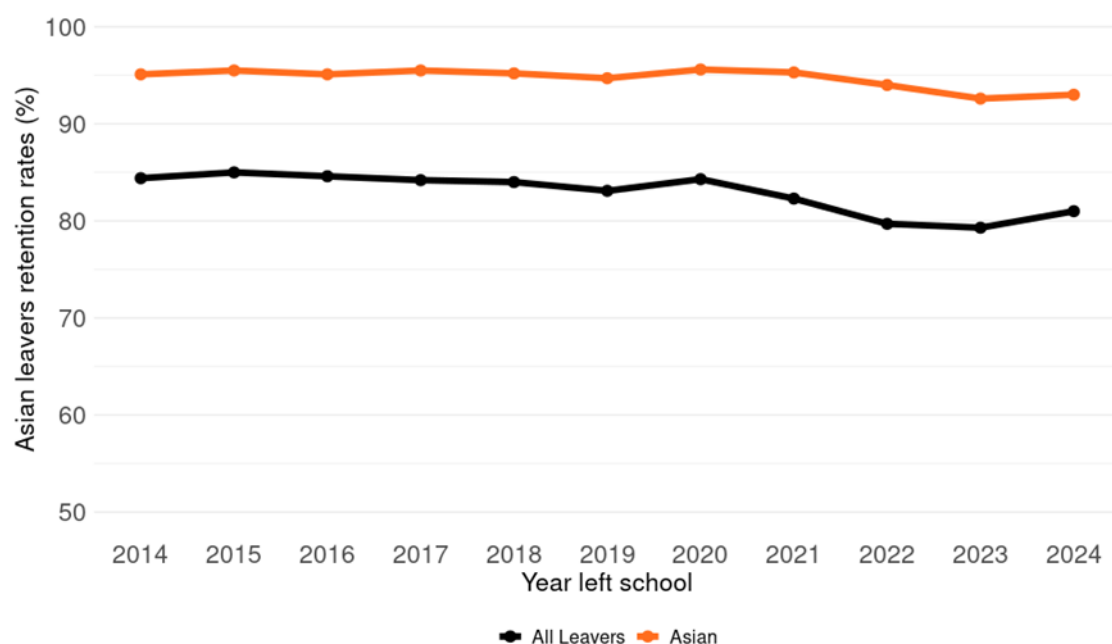
In 2024, 86.1% of Pacific school leavers who stayed in school until at least age 17 attained NCEA Level 2 or above. This was lower than the rates in 2023 (86.2%) and in 2020 (90.0%).



Asian school leavers

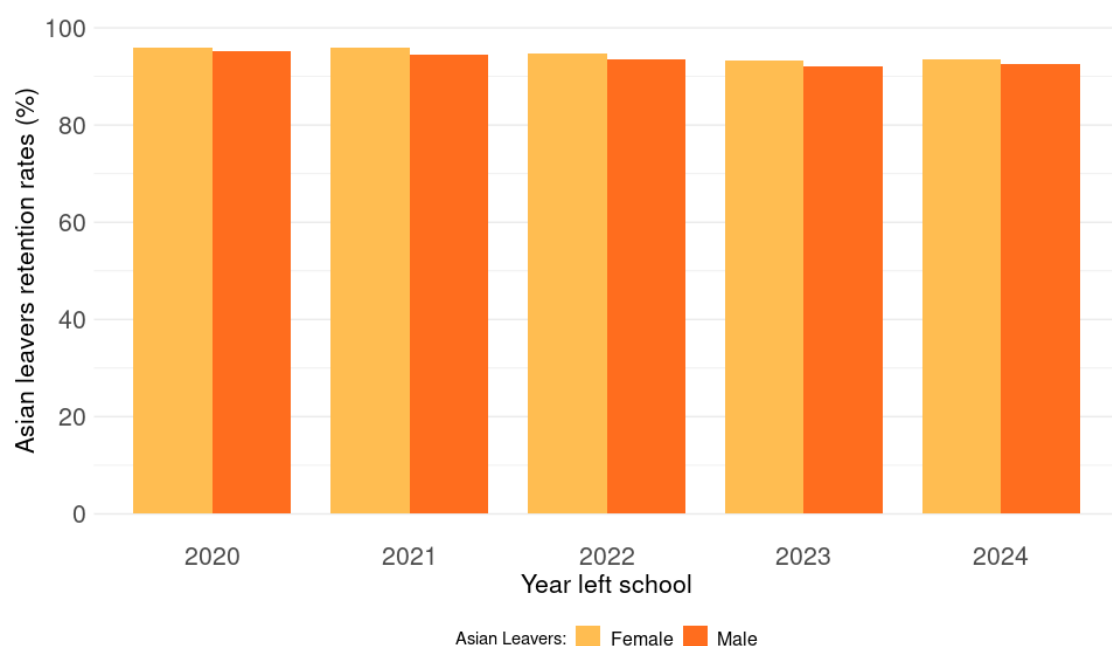
School leavers who identify with an Asian ethnicity had the highest retention rate. The retention rate for Asian school leavers was stable with smaller fluctuations. In 2024, 93.0% of Asian school leavers stayed in school until at least age 17, up 0.4 percentage points from 2023. Between 2020 (the peak point for Asian leavers) and 2024, the rate decreased by 2.6 percentage points (Figure 11).

Figure 11: The retention rate for Asian school leavers was higher than the retention rate for all leavers



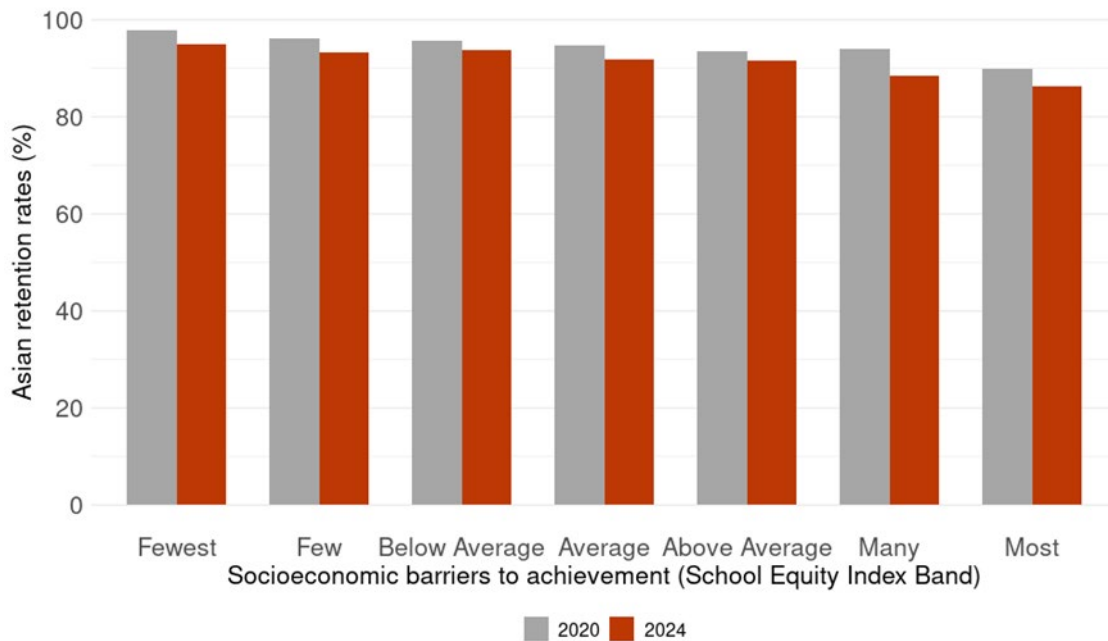
In 2024, 93.5% of Asian female school leavers remained in school until at least age 17 compared to 92.6% of Asian male school leavers (Figure 12).

Figure 12: Proportion of Asian school leavers who remained in school until at least age 17, by gender



The gradient effect for learners in schools where students had fewer barriers to achievement was less evident for Asian learners. In 2024, while a higher proportion of Asian school leavers were from schools where students with the fewest barriers to achievement remained in school until at least age 17 (95%) compared to Asian school leavers from schools where students had the most barriers to achievement (86.3%), the retention rates were higher than the national average (81.0%) for 2024 (Figure 13).

Figure 13: Proportion of Asian school leavers who remained in school until at least age 17, by Equity Index Bands



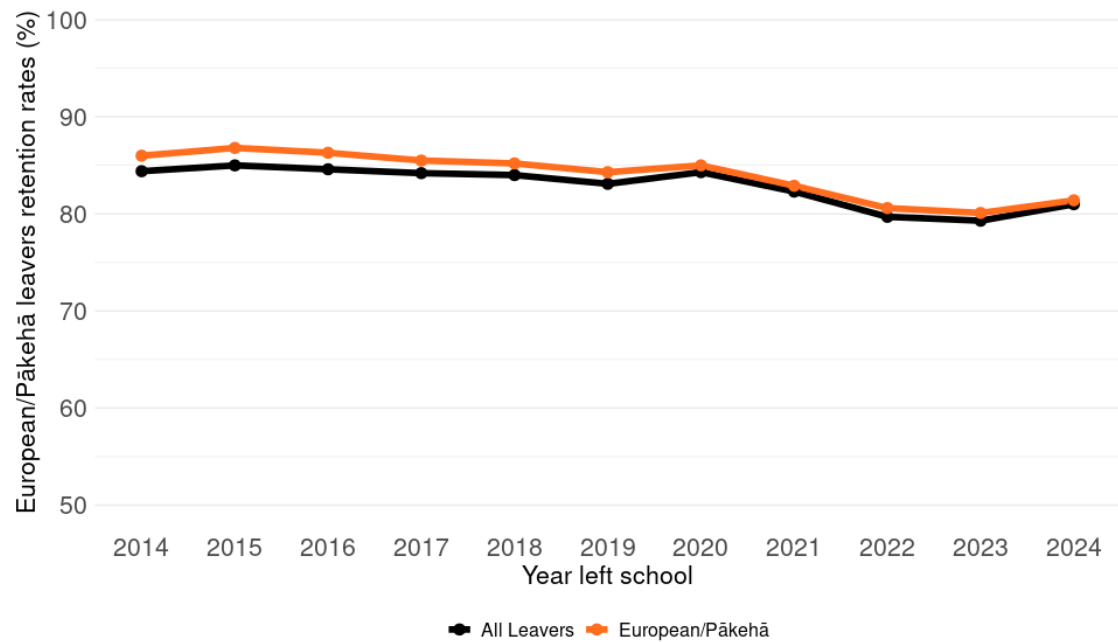
In 2024, 92.0% of Asian school leavers who stayed in school until at least age 17 attained NCEA Level 2 or above. This was lower than in 2023 (92.7%) and 2020 (95.9%).



European/Pākehā school leavers

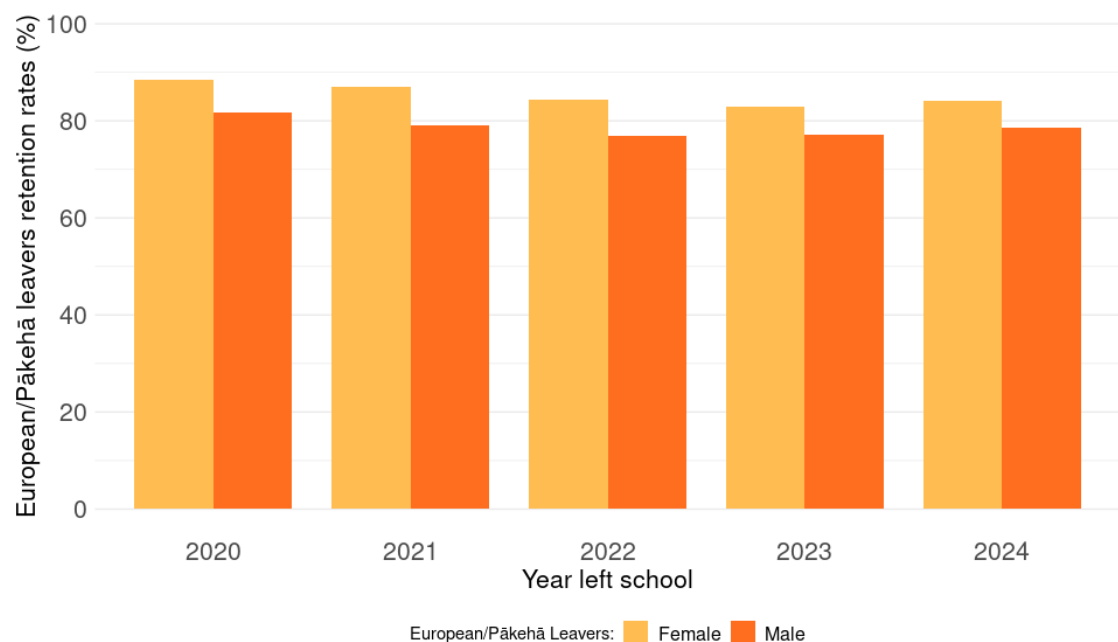
In 2024, 81.4% of European/Pākehā school leavers stayed in school until at least age 17, up 1.3 percentage points from 2023. Between 2015 (the peak point for European/Pākehā leavers) and 2024, the rate decreased by 5.4 percentage points. Between 2020 (the first year of Covid-19) and 2024, the rate decreased by 3.7 percentage points (Figure 14).

Figure 14: The retention rate for European/Pākehā school leavers increased in 2024



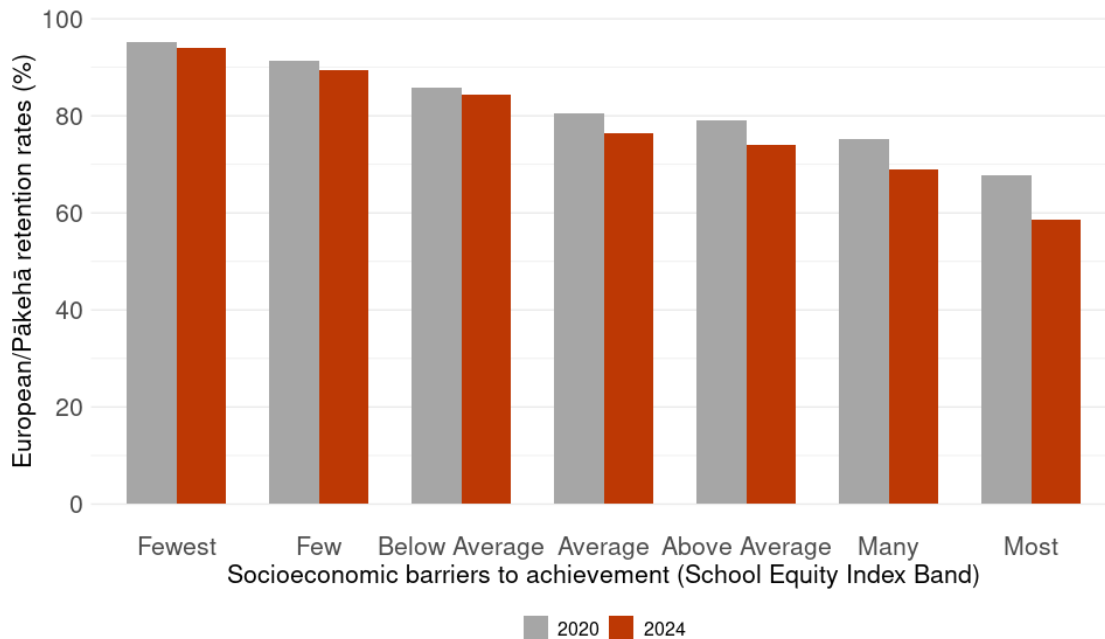
In 2024, 84.2% of European/Pākehā female school leavers remained in school until at least age 17 compared to 78.6% of European/Pākehā male school leavers (Figure 15).

Figure 15: Proportion of European/Pākehā school leavers who remained in school until at least age 17, by gender



A higher proportion of European/Pākehā school leavers from schools where students had fewer barriers to achievement remained in school until at least age 17. In 2024, 94.1% of European/Pākehā from schools where students had the fewest barriers to achievement remained in school compared to 58.6% of European/Pākehā from schools where students had the most barriers to achievement (Figure 16).

Figure 16: Proportion of European/Pākehā school leavers who remained in school until at least age 17, by Equity Index Bands



In 2024, 90.3% of European/Pākehā school leavers who stayed in school until at least age 17 attained NCEA Level 2 or above. This was similar to the rate in 2023 (90.6%) but lower than in 2020 (92.9%).



About equity index reporting

The Ministry has developed a new method of reporting on socioeconomic trends in education statistics called School Equity Index Bands and Groups. These categories estimate the extent to which, on average, students at a school face socioeconomic barriers that could get in the way of their school achievement. There are seven School Equity Index Bands, each containing approximately the same number of schools. Schools are placed into a band based on their Equity Index number. There are three School Equity Index Groups formed by collapsing the seven School Equity Index Bands as indicated in the following diagram. More information on this reporting method can be found on the Ministry's [Education Counts website](#).

Schooling Equity Index Number:



School Equity Index Band:

Fewest	Few	Below Average	Average	Above Average	Many	Most

Socioeconomic barriers to achievement

School Equity Index Group:

Fewer	Moderate	More

Socioeconomic barriers to achievement

Where to find out more

To obtain more information about student attainment see:

- [Tracked Year 11 cohort – Attainment timeframes for Level 2 certificate](#)
- [School leaver pathways](#)
- [School leavers attainment](#)

References

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